

opting to bat first in 44 games.

The decision made by a team after winning the toss represents the strategy it believes will maximise its chances of winning a given match, and thus, such a ratio so heavily skewed in favour of chasing begs the question: is chasing an obviously better strategy in the WPL?

### Is chasing better?

There are a number of reasons why teams tend to prefer chasing — especially in T20 cricket. Speaking after a league-phase game against Delhi Capitals, Smriti Mandhana said, “Chasing a total is a lot easier than setting, because as a batter you don’t always know what’s good enough.”

Aside from simply knowing the equation required for victory, conditions also play a key role. Like most T20 games, a majority of WPL matches are day-night fixtures,

meaning that dew can come into the game as it progresses.

So while there is intuitive reasoning to explain a preference to chase, do the numbers bear out a significant advantage towards it?

Across the 88 WPL games that have taken place over four seasons, 53 have been won by the side chasing (one of them via Super Over). Breaking the numbers into two phases — 2023–24 and 2025–26 — highlights the shift. In the latter period, just one captain elected to bat first compared to 43 who chose to chase. The earlier phase was almost evenly split, with 21 decisions to bat and 23 to field. [See Fig. 1]

On the field, the picture is far more even. In Period 1, teams batting first won 18 of 44 matches, compared to 26 victories for chasing sides. Period 2 shows only a slight shift, with a 17–27 split in favour of chasers. In other words,

the results are nowhere near as dramatic as the swing in toss decisions. [See Fig. 2]

### Splitting by venue

A venue has a huge role to play in determining a team’s optimal course to victory — a key difference between the WPL and several other major franchise leagues. Rather than teams playing in a home-and-away format, the WPL follows a caravan format where one leg is conducted in one venue before moving to another.

The WPL caravan has been to six different venues: Navi Mumbai, Brabourne Stadium, Bengaluru, Delhi, Lucknow, and Vadodara. Delhi is the only one where sides batting first have won significantly more often.

Of the six, Navi Mumbai, Brabourne Stadium, Bengaluru, and Vadodara have hosted more than one leg of the tournament.

A pattern is visible when looking at these grounds by record. In all four, chasing teams tend to win more in the first leg conducted at them, but that bias narrows significantly in the second leg at three of them.



**Quickfire impact:** Radha Yadav played a crucial cameo to steer RCB over the finish line during its chase in the final. PTI